



► Horses show improvement, 1C; South girls claim conference title, 1

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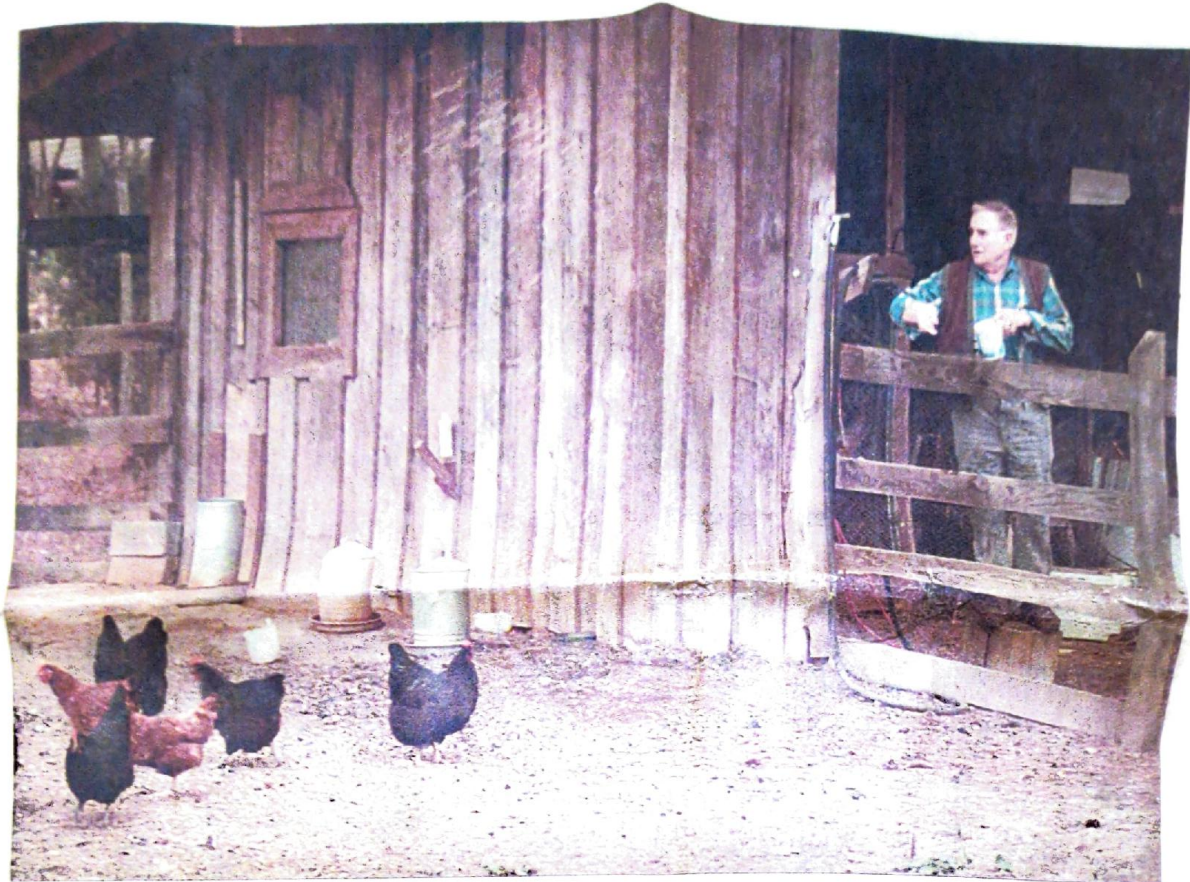


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for apologies Clinton looks to reconciliation, renewal

Hawk on the hunt



WAYNE HINSHAW / SALISBURY POST

WATCHING OVER THE FLOCK: Carrol Fisher spreads feed to his remaining chickens.

Raptor develops taste for chicken

BY MATTHEW WINTER

SALISBURY POST

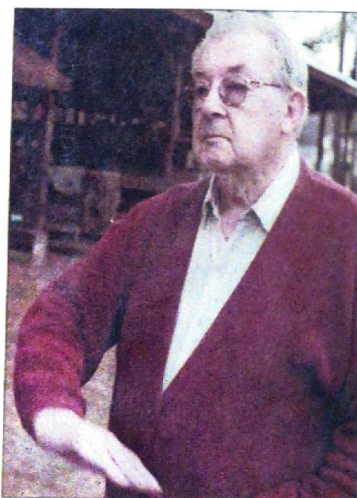
Death from the skies ... unadulterated terror ... a bloody demise.

Murder (of) most fowl is taking place right under our noses, and nobody cares, including the government.

No one except Carrol Fisher, who has mourned the brutal murders of five of his prized free-range chickens.

Just last Sunday, he lost another large black hen. The surviving chickens, he claims, are "very emotionally damaged."

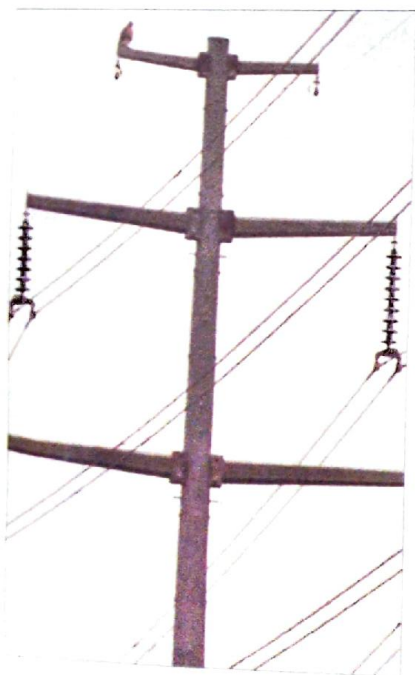
"The worst thing is, these poor chickens are terrified," Fisher explained outside his posh country home off Sells Road, his voice a mix of rascally laughter and indignation. "I mean, anything — the tree shakes, they go screaming into the house. An ol' black crow flies over, they go screaming into the house."



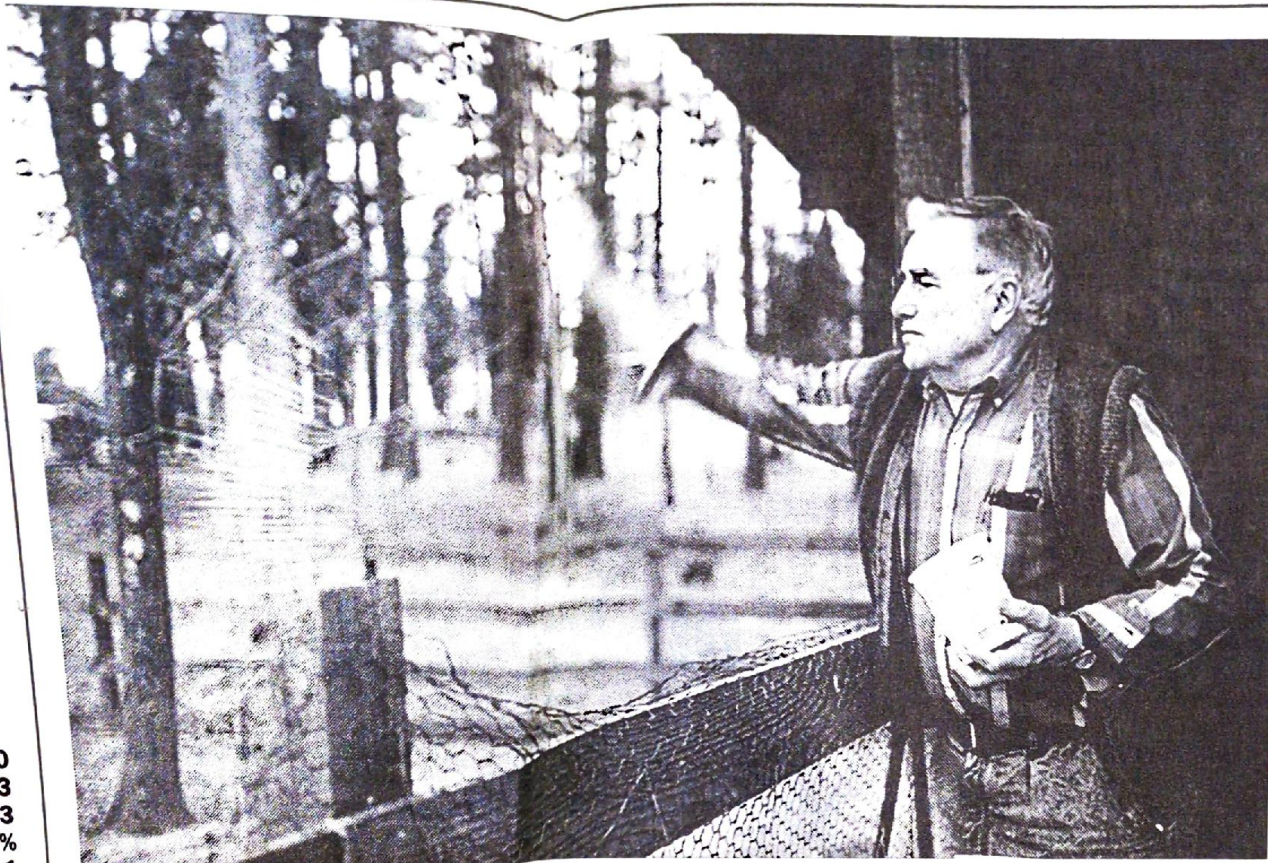
EYEWITNESS: Wade Wise, a neighbor, said the killer hawk looks a lot like an eagle.

"I can't protect my poor ol' chickens. They're at the mercy of that stupid hawk."

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ON THE PROWL: A hawk surveys the scene from high atop the power lines.



WAYNE HINSHAW/SALISBURY POST

HAS HAWK HAD HIS FILL? Carrol Fisher admits his 'poor ol' chickens ... are at the mercy of that stupid hawk.'

Hawk

► From Page 1A

Although the sight of the graceful and powerful red-tailed hawk may delight many nature lovers across Rowan County, Fisher sees the admittedly "gorgeous animal" as what it really is — a killer.

Although Fisher, the retired founder of Carrol Fisher Construction and Fisher Realty, has always suspected who was to blame for killing and eating his chickens to the bone, Sunday was the first time there's been a witness to the crime.

Wade Wise, Fisher's neighbor, was bringing some table scraps for the chickens when the site of a half-eaten hen inside Fisher's 10,000-square-foot pen stopped him short. Wise left and snuck back in a few minutes.

There, sitting on a fence post, was the culprit.

"I'd compare him to an eagle, just about," Wise recalled.

Edy MacDonald, education director at the Carolina Raptor Center, confirmed by phone Friday that if a predatory bird has been hunting

coming in contact with people more and more.

Last year, the Raptor Center treated a record number — 500 to 600 — of injured owls, hawks and eagles. About half were released back into the wild, others were put down, kept at the center or adopted by zoos, museums and conservation groups.

Fisher first noticed the presence of such a large and efficient predator on his property about two years ago. One of his black hens had just mothered a brood of chicks. She was out in the fenced, open-air pen when the hawk attacked.

"You know how the mother hen tries to protect her babies? Well that joker killed her and ate her for it," Fisher bemoaned as he stood at the pen and scattered feed pellets for the pecking chickens.

The hawk returned again in two months, devouring another member of the growing brood, Fisher said. The raptor returned in a few more months and consumed yet another hen.

The most hurtful loss, however, came months later, when one of that orphaned brood had

the chickens.

The last straw in this pitched battle came Sunday, when the hawk apparently swooped down and seized another hen. With the hawk between them and the safety of their coop, the seven remaining chickens — including the runt rooster — scrambled into a small dog house on the opposite end of the pen.

They stayed in the doghouse until Wise scared off the hawk and shooed them out.

"It was just terrible the way they were all jammed in that little ol' house — every one in that little house," Fisher said, shaking his head as Wise stood grinning nearby.

And those big, brown, speckled eggs he used to give away to neighbors — Fisher could only find one in the dark, dry hen boxes inside the coop Thursday.

"They've been so full of terror they can't even lay eggs," he said.

When asked what stopped him from taking matters — and a shotgun — into his own hands, Fisher hesitated.

"Well, we have some reservations about that," he said. "I

has always suspected who was to blame for killing and eating his chickens to the bone, Sunday was the first time there's been a witness to the crime.

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There, sitting on a fence post, was the culprit.

"I'd compare him to an eagle, just about," Wise recalled.

Edy MacDonald, education director at the Carolina Raptor Center, confirmed by phone Friday that if a predatory bird has been hunting Fisher's chickens, it's probably a red-tailed hawk.

Female red-tailed hawks, as with many types of birds are bigger than males and can grow up to 6 pounds. They can appear much larger, as their hollow bones and feathers belie their relatively light weight, MacDonald pointed out.

Although MacDonald was skeptical that even a larger red-tailed hawk could take a 7-pound chicken, she said there's virtually no chance one of the region's handful of bald eagles is to blame. Bald eagles eat fish exclusively, she explained.

Red-tailed hawks are generalists, meaning they will eat a range of small mammals, birds and reptiles. They prefer hunting over open terrain, such as the open grassland and sparse woodlands surrounding Fisher's chicken pen.

MacDonald said biologists aren't sure if the red-tailed hawk population in the Piedmont is growing or declining, but she did say that because of urban sprawl, the birds are

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"You know how the mother hen tries to protect her babies? Well that joker killed her and ate her for it," Fisher bemoaned as he stood at the pen and scattered feed pellets for the pecking chickens.

The hawk returned again in two months, devouring another member of the growing brood, Fisher said. The raptor returned in a few more months and consumed yet another hen.

The most hurtful loss, however, came months later, when one of that orphaned brood had grown into a "beautiful large rooster" with striking neck and tail feathers and a crow that brought joy into Fisher's heart.

The rooster's chivalrous nature cost him his life, Fisher theorized.

When the hawk swooped in for the kill, the rooster must have gallantly warned the hens and gave them time to make it back into the coop, Fisher explained.

"While he was being the hero, that John Brown hawk came in and killed him," he said, slapping one hand on top the other. "You can go by there and find a pile of feathers and bones."

This week, Fisher bitterly mourned the loss of that rooster. His replacement rooster is "a little ol' minuscule rooster" who doesn't even crow.

Although Fisher admits that different hawks could have done the killing, he always refers to one large hawk that has a penchant for sitting on nearby power lines watching

and shooed them out. "It was just terrible the way they were all jammed in that little ol' house — every one in that little house," Fisher said, shaking his head as Wise stood grinning nearby.

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"They've been so full of terror they can't even lay eggs," he said.

When asked what stopped him from taking matters — and a shotgun — into his own hands, Fisher hesitated.

"Well, we have some reservations about that," he said. "I think the fine if they catch you is \$10,000."

Indeed, anyone caught injuring or killing a predatory bird, or even possessing their feathers, could be forced to pay thousands of dollars in fines and serve time in jail.

Fisher did call game wardens, though, seeking permission to shoot the bane of his chicken coop.

The wardens apparently gave him a blunt "No," and advised him to provide his chickens with a more protective pen.

But keeping the chickens in a small cage leaves a sour taste in Fisher's mouth, for the sake of the chickens and his omelettes.

So for the time being, Fisher is considering building some sort of sheltered pen. Or he may just learn to live with the occasional loss to his egg business.

"What do you think," he asked. "Can I claim it on my taxes?"

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